was not such an easy task, especially to the summit level. Moreover, his besetting weakness was a tendency to lose his temper and expend his powers on the immediate provocation. And those happened to be many, some deriving from his enmity towards Vasistha, but others being distractions deliberately put in his way. Not content with being recognized by Lord Brahma as a '*rajarishi*', he ultimately pushed himself to attain the highest status of '*brahmarishi*'. But even then, Kaushika was not satisfied until he heard this recognition from the lips of Vasistha himself.

This tale of the two sages has some resemblance to developments in current world affairs. Rising powers are constantly pushing themselves, with the established one as the standard to be matched. Some may be driven by memories of humiliation, even if others are more at peace with themselves. In this process of reordering, only gaining the respect of competitors is not always enough. There is equally a deep desire to be formally acknowledged as an equal. The fire inside, which drives such a quest, can encourage a mentality of winning at any cost. And that, today, is understandably the biggest challenge to the establishment of a rules-based order. Not to forget, entrenched powers such as Sage Vasistha have a deeper influence that cannot be easily overcome.

If there is another trait that has carried on uninterrupted in history, it is that of political suspicion. Much as they may deny, even the closest of partners watch each other for contrary signs. It is a moot question whether the absence of her own son Bharata on the day of Rama's coronation added to Queen Kaikeyi's anxieties about his (and her) future. Certainly, these thoughts would have been magnified by her evil help Manthara, who had instigated her to make unreasonable demands by invoking the two boons given by King Dasaratha. This, incidentally, is also a telling example of how a smaller player with their own agenda can take advantage of the insecurities of a larger one. We can see that happening in our own neighbourhood.

But personalities aside, the hard realities that underpin international relations are those of competition and benefits. For all the talk of globalization and common good, nations still calculate unsentimentally what is to their particular advantage. The world may be changing but, in some respects, the more it does, the more it remains the same.

BEYOND WESTPHALIAN POLITICS

While it is natural to visualize the developments pertaining to the US and China in a related manner, it would nevertheless be an oversimplification to see them as a zero-sum game. To begin with, both of them are aspects of a larger rebalancing that is taking place in the world. Certainly, they have impacted each other and there are causal connections. American retrenchment has provided greater space to Chinese influence, given that it extends across so many domains. As much of the world put the colonial period behind, new centres of economic activities inevitably came into being. Of course, the pace and quality of this transformation was shaped by political choices, especially of the US.